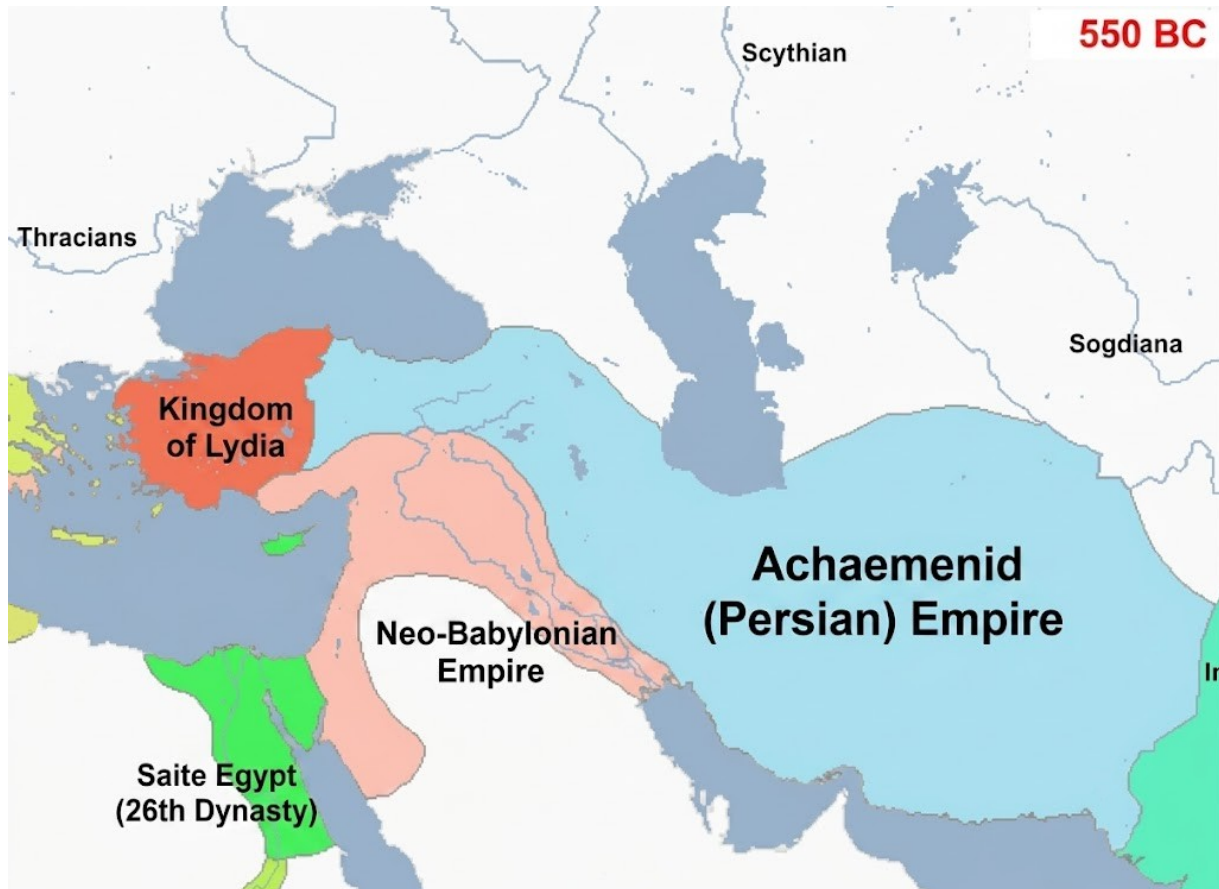


Achaemenid Conquest of the Near East v0.7



OVERVIEW: The Persian conquests occurred on the border between the Iron Age and Classical Antiquity, spanning 550–510 BCE, when Cyrus the Great (and his successors) forged the Achaemenid Empire during the late Iron Age, dismantling the ancient empires of Lydia, Babylon, and Egypt. This expansion of a Persian Empire would come into contact with Ionian Greeks, eventually cascading into the Greco-Persian Wars, often argued as the dawn of a western civilization.

Detailed Information:

Cyrus II united Persia by rebelling against Median rule, against his grandfather, King Astyages, in 550 BCE. He defeated the Median Empire and merged it with his Persian

kingdom of Anshan to form what is now known as the Achaemenid Empire, named after his dynasty. His empire had adopted Zoroastrianism as its guiding religious framework. Next, Cyrus II would conduct military campaigns against Lydia and the Neo-Babylonian Empire, both being successful. After conquering Babylon, he demonstrated remarkable religious tolerance by allowing exiled peoples, including the Jews, to return to their homelands and rebuild their temple, freeing them from Babylonian captivity. Though highly disputed, it is said that Cyrus II died in battle against the Scythians, in an attempt to add even more land to his empire. As for his legacy, Cyrus II would be referred to as Cyrus "the Great" by Greek historians such as Herodotus in the 5th century BCE.

While many academic scholars identify the Quranic figure of Dhul-Qarnayn (Zulkarnain) with Alexander the Great, a more modern interpretation makes the case for Cyrus the Great instead. This view was notably argued by Allamah Tabatabai, a leading 20th-century Iranian Shia philosopher and Quranic exegete, who in his Quranic commentary "Al-Mizan fi Tafsir al-Qur'an" challenged the Alexander identification and pointed to Cyrus's monotheistic-leaning piety and vast east-west empire. Overall, Cyrus represents an important part of contemporary Iranian culture. In recent months, Iranian protesters (and Iranian-American exiles) have invoked Cyrus the Great's legacy of tolerance, justice, and human rights to protest the theocratic regime.

Cambyes II, the eldest son and successor of Cyrus the Great, ascended to the Achaemenid throne in 530 BCE and continued his father's expansionist policies by launching a successful campaign against Egypt in 525 BCE, defeating Pharaoh Psamtik III at the Battle of Pelusium. Herodotus writes of that battle saying Persian forces exploited the

Egyptians' sacred reverence for cats by painting feline images on shields or carrying live cats into battle, causing the enemy to falter rather than harm the animals. There were many exaggerated, fanciful, or legendary stories in regards to Cambyses II, depicting him as increasingly tyrannical and mad. Such tales include:

1. **The Apis Bull:** Herodotus claims that Cambyses, arriving in Memphis after conquering Egypt, stabbed the sacred Apis bull in the thigh to mock Egyptian worship, wounding it so badly that it later died.
2. **The Lost Army of Cambyses:** It's said that Cambyses II ordered a military expedition to the Siwa Oasis to destroy the Oracle of Amun, a religious site that held immense political and psychological power over the Egyptian people. The supposed force of 50,000 Persian soldiers is said to have vanished entirely in a massive sandstorm during the march. Numerous archeology expeditions (1930s, 1980s, 2000, & 2009) have searched for archaeological evidence of this, producing some tantalizing finds (bones, weapons, and a possible Persian bracelet), but none have been widely accepted as definitive proof.
3. **Familial Cruelty:** Herodotus details Cambyses murdering his brother Bardiya fearing he would seize the throne, and marrying his own sister to consolidate dynastic power.

Whether rooted in truth or complete fabrication, it's clear that Greek literature leaned into the theme of hubris (excessive pride). By portraying Persian Kings as unstable tyrants, Greek writers could highlight the superiority of Greek democratic ideals over Eastern "despotism." After the GrecoPersian War, Athens launched a massive military intervention to help Egypt rebel against Persia during the Egyptian Revolt of Inaros (460–454 BCE).

Auxiliary Historical Information:

Despite surviving the Bronze Age Collapse, Egypt's New Kingdom declined due to economic strain, droughts, famines, and corruption, which produced weak pharaohs unable to counter the rising power of Theban priests. This culminated in Egypt's division between northern pharaohs and southern priestly rulers. The Third Intermediate Period followed, characterized with Libyan and Nubian ruling dynasties. This era ended when the Assyrians invaded and sacked Thebes in 663 BC, expelling the Nubians. Psamtik I of Sais, initially an Assyrian vassal, reunited Egypt through diplomacy and military force, peacefully securing Egypt and founding the 26th Dynasty.

The Neo-Assyrian Empire rose from the ashes of earlier Assyrian kingdoms through a series of aggressive military reforms and expansionist campaigns. At its height, the empire stretched from Mesopotamia to Egypt, dominating the ancient Near East with an iron fist. The Babylonians and Medes, both long-suffering under brutal Assyrian domination and deportation, united.



'The Fall of Nineveh' by John Martin (1829).

The 1829 painting depicts the 612 BCE destruction of the Assyrian capital by a Medo-Babylonian alliance, which happens just before my simulation's start date. It marked the end of the NeoAssyrian Empire and the beginning of the Neo-Babylonian Empire. This empire would itself fall to the Achaemenid Persian Empire in 539 BCE.

Elsewhere, the Kingdom of Lydia in western Anatolia during the 7th century BCE, growing rich from the gold-bearing waters of the river Pactolus. Lydia's prosperity made it a major player in Aegean trade and politics, exerting influence over the Greek cities of the Ionian coast. In the north, roaming the vast grasslands of the Pontic Steppe, were the Scythians. They were masters of horse warfare. Their warrior culture is vividly preserved in the great burial mounds, or kurgans, scattered across Ukraine, where excavations have unearthed elaborate golden artifacts and weapons buried alongside their chiefs.

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Friendly Reminder: Stone Age → Bronze Age → Iron Age → Classical Antiquity